Britain’s domestic situation goes some way perhaps in explaining the Home government’s consistent preoccupation with the threat of Bolshevism.

With Britain in domestic turmoil, drastic measures were needed in order to bring the economic problem under control and thus reduce popular agitation.[11] Given the financial constraints facing the government, an extensive military machine was an obvious target for cost-cutting. By April 1920 the army constituted about 173,000 more men than seven years earlier, and cost approximately twice as much.[12] Unsurprisingly, the secretary of state for war, Winston Churchill, faced intense pressure to reduce the financial burden of the army on the Treasury. However, the cost of the army was clearly a reflection of its size, which in turn was a consequence of the large number of arenas where British forces were stationed. After 1918, British troops were to be found in countries across the northern hemisphere, including, among others, France, Germany, Italy, Greece, Austria-Hungary, Serbia, Bulgaria, the Ottoman Empire, Persia, Mesopotamia, Egypt, Ireland and not forgetting the interventionist forces in Russia.[13] Thus, there was a fundamental disparity between the need to rapidly reduce the army and the level of responsibility that the British Army held in the post-war period.

Something was going to have to give and for Churchill, it was going to have to be the extent of Britain’s military presence in Asia. In February 1920, for example, the secretary of state attacked the excessive price of maintaining troops in places such as Mesopotamia.[14] To Wilson, however, Mesopotamia was one of five countries that were essential to the security of the British Empire as a whole.[15] The director of military operations, General Radcliffe, also agreed that a reduction of British forces in Mesopotamia would lead to anarchy, which could have negative consequences for India.[16] Nevertheless, Churchill would not let the matter of Mesopotamia rest. In May, he submitted another memorandum to Cabinet in which he tried ‘to draw the attention of my colleagues to the waste of money entailed by our present military and administrative policy in Mesopotamia’, and asked them to make the decision for ‘a prompt and drastic curtailment of expenditure’.[17] In his cost-cutting endeavours the secretary of state for war even explored using the RAF in Mesopotamia.[18] In the opinion of Wilson, Churchill ‘regardless of safety and hoping that any disasters may come after he has left office, is trying to gain credit and make a name by saving money’.[19]